BON Appetit Korea – Store #1 Plan: Sindang

A compact first store in Seoul, run as a pilot

October 2026 · All amounts are estimates in KRW (USD 1 = KRW 1,331.4, 16 Oct 2026). VAT not included unless stated.

Dear BON Appetit Team,

Thank you for your detailed feedback on the Itaewon plan. You asked us to keep the budget comfortable, to start with a smaller first phase, and to think carefully about late-night trade. With this in mind, we would like to propose a different approach for store #1: a compact store in Sindang, inside the Jungang Market area, which the Seoul city government has just started to redesign.

We see store #1 as a pilot. It lets us test the menu, prices, takeaway and delivery with Korean customers at about one third of the Itaewon budget. Once we know what works, we can open a late-night store in a nightlife area as the next step.

Because Sindang is less known to visitors than Itaewon, this document first explains the neighbourhood and the market redesign, then the site, our cost estimate and how we would measure the pilot.

KRW 10M	**KRW 1.3M**	**≈ KRW 99M**	**53–54**
Deposit (returned at the end of the lease)	Monthly rent	Total funds needed, incl. deposit and 3 months of costs (before any key money)	Tacos a day to break even

At a glance

Location	Jungang Market area by Sindang Station (Lines 2 and 6), Jung-gu, central Seoul. One stop to Dongdaemun Design Plaza (DDP), five stops to Itaewon.
Space	About 33 m² (10 pyeong) on the ground floor, inside the covered market lane. A small restaurant operates there today.
Lease	Deposit KRW 10M, rent KRW 1.3M a month. Key money (if any) to be confirmed.
Format	Counter kitchen facing the market lane, where guests watch their taco being made; 12–16 seats inside; takeaway and delivery.
Hours	11:00–23:00. Later closing on Friday and Saturday will be tested.
Budget	About KRW 99M (USD 75k) in total, compared with KRW 318–389M for the Itaewon building plan.
Next step	A late-night store in a nightlife area (Itaewon Station area or Dongdaemun), chosen with night-time foot-traffic counts.

Sindang: a neighbourhood guide

2 + 6	1 stop	+673%	45%
Subway lines at Sindang Station	to DDP on Line 2	Small-pub card spending in 5 years	Single-person households in Sindang-dong

Where it is. Sindang is in Jung-gu, the historic centre of Seoul, about 1 km east of Dongdaemun Design Plaza (DDP). Sindang Station is a transfer station on Lines 2 and 6: one stop to DDP, four stops to Euljiro (near Myeong-dong) and five stops on Line 6 to Itaewon.

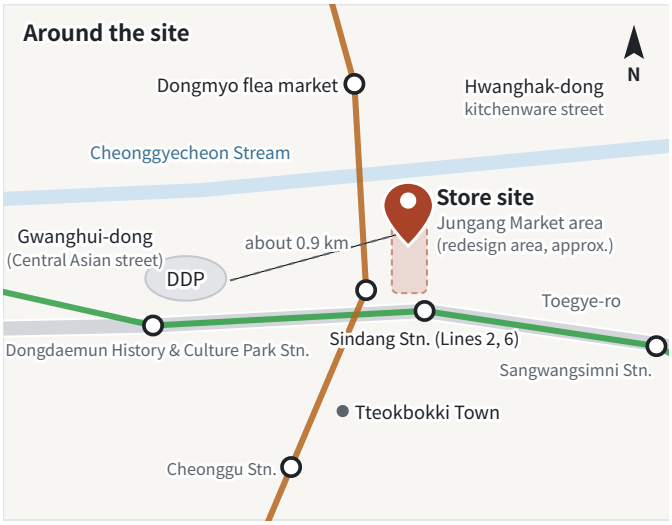
A bit of history. The name comes from the shrines (sindang) that stood outside Gwanghuimun Gate in the Joseon era. Since the 1970s the area has been known for its tteokbokki alley (spicy rice cakes) and for its large traditional market, famous for grilled tripe (gopchang) and fresh produce. Just north is Hwanghak-dong, Seoul's kitchen-equipment street, next to the Dongmyo flea market.

"Hipdang-dong". Young Koreans now call the area "Hipdang-dong" (hip + Sindang-dong). Small bars and restaurants have opened in old market buildings and side streets, more than 40 in 2023 alone. Card spending at small pubs in the area grew 673% over five years (KB Kookmin Card, 2024). Foreign guests are increasing as well: one well-known bar owner told Korea JoongAng Daily (2024) that about 40% of weekday guests are foreigners.

Who lives here. Sindang-dong has about 63,000 residents in 32,000 households, and 45% of households are single-person homes, a good base for delivery and takeaway. The Dongdaemun and Euljiro business areas are within delivery range.

Seoul's plans. The city wants to link DDP, Hipdang-dong, the tteokbokki alley and Gwanghui-dong (Seoul's Central Asian street) into one food and night-tourism belt, with the redesigned market at its centre. Korea welcomed a record 18.9 million foreign visitors in 2025.



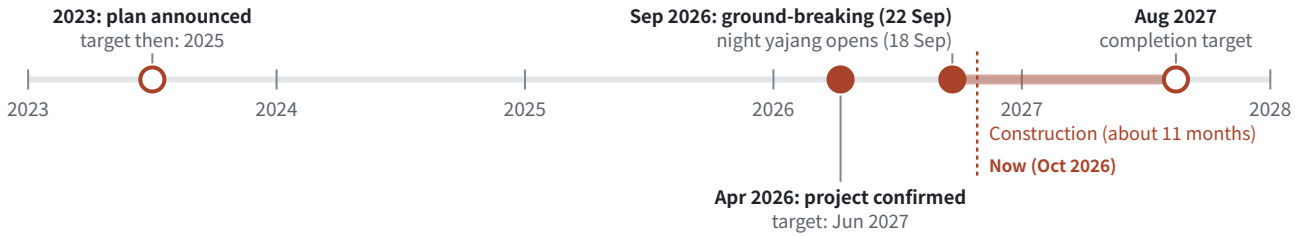


Simplified maps. Station and place positions are approximate.

Sources: KB Kookmin Card business-area report (2024); Korea JoongAng Daily (2024); Korea Times (2024); resident statistics, June 2026; Seoul Metropolitan Government and news reports (2026); Korea Tourism data for 2025.

The market redesign

Seoul has started a city-funded redesign of the Jungang Market area by Sindang Station. It is the first project to break ground under the city's “Design Innovation Traditional Market” programme. The goal is a market that visitors from Korea and abroad enjoy, and a centre for the area's food and night life.



Programme	Seoul Metropolitan Government, “Design Innovation Traditional Market” (first project to start)
Budget	About KRW 18.7 billion in total (Sep 2026); arcade works about KRW 15.5 billion (Apr 2026)
Schedule	Ground-breaking 22 Sep 2026; completion target Aug 2027 (earlier target Jun 2027, delays possible)
Main works	The old arcade is replaced by a timber roof that lets in daylight (about 15 m wide and 275 m long, about 130 shops); a tiered seating and rest area; “open roofs” at the entrances of 16 side alleys; overhead power cables tidied
Night programme	Jung-gu district and the merchants' associations run a night “yajang” (outdoor tables) programme from 18:00 to 23:00; 34 shops in this market take part. Food is cooked indoors and served outside. The district is revising its outdoor-dining rules, and Seoul plans to expand its night markets to 25 sites by 2028.
Politics	The mayor who launched the programme was re-elected in June 2026, so the policy is expected to continue.

What this means for us

- The redesign should bring more visitors, better seating and a stronger image to the market.
- Until about August 2027, the market will be partly under construction. We will link the start of the lease and our fit-out to the works schedule for our section, and we will not open in the middle of the works in front of the store.
- Before signing, we will get written confirmation that kitchen exhaust can pass through the new roof.

Sources: Kyunghyang Shinmun, News1, Discovery News, Asia Today (22 Sep 2026); Newsis, eToday (Apr 2026); Herald Business, Jung-gu News, eToday (Sep 2026, night programme); Asia Economy (Oct 2026, outdoor-dining rules); Money Today (Sep 2026, night markets); Newsis (Jun 2026, election).

The site



Storefront in the covered market lane, next to a fried-chicken shop



Counter kitchen at the front, with the dining room behind



Existing counter kitchen (gas range, sink) facing the market lane



Dining room with 3–4 tables (12–16 seats)

Photos: listing photos from the local broker (Hanyang Leaps Realty). Contact details on the current tenant's sign are blurred.

Address	Toegye-ro 85-gil 37 (Hwanghak-dong), Jung-gu, Seoul: inside the market lane near Sindang Station. Its exact position within the redesign area will be confirmed with the project office.
Size	About 33 m² (10 pyeong), ground floor
Today	A small Korean restaurant: stainless counter kitchen facing the lane, gas range, double sink, exhaust duct, chest freezer; small dining room
Lease	Deposit KRW 10M; rent KRW 1.3M a month; key money to be confirmed. Korean law lets the tenant renew for up to 10 years, with each rent increase capped at 5%.

How we would use the space

- The counter facing the lane becomes the order line: guests choose fillings and watch their taco being grilled, as in Bali.
- Inside: 12–16 seats with self-service. At the front: a pickup shelf for delivery riders.
- If the store joins the district's night programme, a few outdoor tables can be added (food cooked inside). Our plan does not count on them.

Operating plan and costs

Hours	11:00–23:00, every day. We will test later closing on Friday and Saturday.
Staff	2 people at lunch and evening peaks, 1 in the afternoon. The owner is based 2 minutes' walk away.
Kitchen	Two contact grills (a third if needed), a gas fryer on the existing gas line, a topping display fridge and a cheese-sauce warmer. An electricity upgrade to about 12 kW is likely; we will confirm it.
Sales mix (plan)	Dine-in 25–35%, takeaway about 25%, delivery 40–50%. Average taco KRW 13,500 (to be set with you).

Startup investment (base case)

Item	KRW	USD
Security deposit (returned at the end of the lease)	10.0M	8k
Lease costs (broker fee, rent during fit-out)	2.5M	2k
Fit-out and building services (incl. exhaust, gas, electricity upgrade)	15.2M	11k
Kitchen equipment	8.5M	6k
Signage, furniture and IT	6.3M	5k
Opening stock, sauce import, permits and training	9.0M	7k
Opening marketing	3.5M	3k
Contingency (12.5%)	3.8M	3k
Subtotal: startup investment	**58.8M**	**44k**
Working capital, 3 months of fixed costs	40.6M	30k
Total funds needed	**99.4M**	**75k**
Key money to the current tenant, if any (not included)		to be confirmed

Range before key money: about KRW 67M–155M. With key money of KRW 15M the total would be about KRW 114M; with KRW 35M, about KRW 134M. The money actually spent (excluding deposit and working capital) is about KRW 49M in the base case.

Monthly fixed costs

Item	KRW / month
Rent	1.3M
Market management fee and association dues (estimate)	0.2M
Staff (22–23 staff hours a day, incl. a shift-lead allowance)	10.0–10.5M
Utilities	0.85M
Other (accounting, insurance, POS, delivery-app ads)	0.7M
Total	**13.1–13.5M**

Break-even

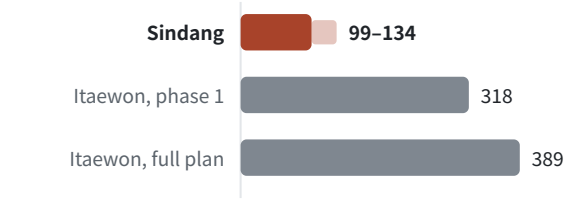
About 53–54 tacos a day, or about KRW 27.5M of sales a month (incl. VAT). For example, 14–20 dine-in guests, 12–13 takeaway orders and 14–18 delivery orders a day. Average ticket: KRW 16,000 per dine-in guest, KRW 18,000 per takeaway order, KRW 26,000 per delivery order. Royalty is not included.

Sindang compared with the Itaewon plan

	Sindang (this plan)	Itaewon building, phase 1	Itaewon building, full plan
Deposit / monthly rent	**KRW 10M / 1.3M**	KRW 100M / 5.0M	KRW 100M / 5.0M
Money actually spent	**≈ KRW 49M (+ key money)**	≈ KRW 158M	≈ KRW 222M
Total funds needed	**≈ KRW 99M (+ key money)**	≈ KRW 318M	≈ KRW 389M
Monthly fixed costs	**≈ KRW 13.1–13.5M**	≈ KRW 21.3M	≈ KRW 21.3M
Break-even (tacos a day)	**53–54**	≈ 85	≈ 85
Downside: 30 tacos a day, closed after 12 months	**≈ KRW 120–160M**	≈ KRW 330M	higher
Late-night potential	**Low: night programme ends 23:00**	Medium: about 700 m from the main nightlife street	Medium
Seats	**12–16 (+ outdoor tables if allowed)**	≈ 14 (+ rooftop in phase 2)	≈ 42
Main constraint	**Market works until about Aug 2027**	Kitchen floor only 36 m²	Higher budget

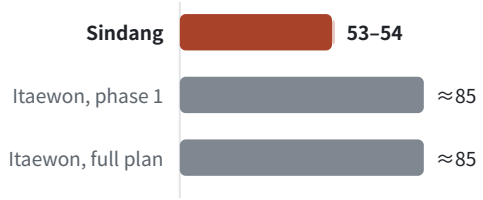
Sindang figures use 11:00–23:00 hours and a gas fryer. Itaewon figures are from our earlier plan. The downside figure excludes the deposit.

Total funds needed (KRW million)



Sindang: bar = before key money; light extension = up to KRW 35M key money.

Break-even (tacos a day)



Before royalty and the owner's salary.

How we will measure the pilot

What we measure	Tacos sold per day, sales by channel (dine-in, takeaway, delivery), repeat customers, delivery-app ratings, food cost, and customers' reaction to prices.
Month 3 review	Target: at least 40 tacos a day, delivery rating 4.7 or higher, food cost 35% or lower. If we are below target, we adjust menu, prices and channels.
Month 6 review	Target: around break-even (about 55 tacos a day). At that point we start the search for the late-night store in earnest.
Late-night store	Candidates: the Itaewon Station area and the streets behind the Hamilton Hotel, and Dongdaemun / Gwanghui-dong. We will count foot traffic on Friday and Saturday nights (22:00–04:00) and compare the sites with you.

Risks and how we will handle them

Risk	How we will handle it
Market works until about Aug 2027 (hoarding, dust, fewer visitors)	Link the lease start and fit-out to the works schedule for our section; right to cancel if completion slips; no opening in the middle of the works.
Kitchen exhaust through the new timber roof	Written confirmation from the project office before signing.
Electricity for the grills (about 12 kW needed)	Check the current contract; the gas fryer lowers the load; the upgrade is in the budget.
Outdoor tables not guaranteed (district programme; food cooked indoors only)	Our plan assumes no outdoor seats; any outdoor seats are extra.
Limited late-night trade (night programme ends 23:00)	Close at 23:00; test the late-night model in the next store.
Market shoppers may find the price high	Test prices and portion sizes in the first months, with your guidance.
Rent after the redesign	By law, renewals are possible for up to 10 years, and each rent increase is capped at 5%.
Key money, licence and building use	Confirm the current restaurant licence type, building use and any key money before signing.

Questions for you

1. Does a compact counter-style first store (about 33 m^2, 12–16 seats) fit your brand standards?
2. What is the minimum equipment set? Are two contact grills and a gas fryer acceptable?
3. Do you have interior and signage guidelines that would work for a unit inside a market lane? (The market may also have its own design rules.)
4. Roughly what share of Bali sales comes after midnight, and how is it split between dine-in, takeaway and delivery?
5. How many staff do you have per shift in Bali?
6. Do you have smaller or lower-priced items that could suit market shoppers?
7. Can we discuss commercial terms that suit a pilot-format first store?

We would be happy to go through this plan on a video call. Thank you again for your support.